

simply excluded that person, forever. One shot at building a relationship. Time was scarce.

Warren Buffett as a young man was among the very, very few who impressed my father sufficiently in his first meeting to merit a second meeting and many more meetings after that. My father was a shrewd judge of character and skill. Unusually so! He based his career on judging people. It was one of his best qualities and a major reason why he put so much emphasis on qualitative judgment of business management in his stock analysis. He was always very proud he had picked Warren Buffett as an “A” before Buffett had won his much-deserved fame and acclaim.

The relationship between Warren Buffett and my father survived my father’s occasional lapses when he would mistakenly call Mr. Buffett “Howard” (Warren’s father’s name). This is an unusual story that has never been told and perhaps says much about both my father and Warren Buffett.

My father was a small man with a big mind that raced intensely. While kindly, he was nervous, often agitated, and personally insecure. He was also very, very much a creature of habit. He followed daily catechisms rigorously because they made him more secure. And he loved to sleep, because when he slept, he wasn’t nervous or insecure. So when he couldn’t stop his mind from racing at night, which was often, he played memory games instead of counting sheep. One sleep game he played was memorizing the names and districts of all the members of Congress until he drifted off.

Starting in 1942, he memorized the name of Howard Buffett and associated it with Omaha, over and over again, night after night, for more than a decade. His brain mechanically linked the words “Omaha,” “Buffett,” and “Howard” as a related series long before he met Warren Buffett. Later, as Warren’s career began to build and his star rose, it was still fully two decades before my father could fully disentangle Buffett and Omaha from “Howard.” That annoyed my father because he couldn’t control his mind and because he was fond of Warren Buffett and valued their relationship. Father knew exactly who Warren Buffett was, but in casual conversation he often said something like “That bright young Howard Buffett from Omaha.” The more he said it, the harder it became to eliminate it from his phraseology. A man of habit habitually vexed.